Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), 1967, the central government declared the PFI and eight affiliated organs 'unlawful associations'.

In effect, it became what in popular parlance is known as a banned outfit—India already has a list of 42 such organisations with the last two making an entry in 2019. Most of PFI's top leadership—chairman O.M.A. Abdul Salam, vice-chairman E.M. Abdul Rahiman, general secretary Anis Ahmed, ideologue P. Koya and the heads of several state units—are now in custody facing charges for crimes under the UAPA, such as terror funding, holding camps to impart arms training and promoting enmity among different religious groups.

The government's objective apparently is to root out the entire PFI network, which is why the ban covers eight allied organisations too—Rehab India Foundation, Campus Front of India (students' wing), All India Imams Council, National Confederation of Human Rights Organizations, National Women's Front, Junior Front, Empower India Foundation and Rehab Foundation, Kerala. The central government notification claims these wings had a 'hub and spoke' relationship, with the PFI acting as the hub and utilising the mass outreach and fund-raising capacity of its affiliates to strengthen its capacity for unlawful activities. These fronts 'function as roots and capillaries through which the PFI is fed and strengthened', read the notification.

The affiliates reject such claims. For instance, though arrested PFI leaders Koya, Rahiman and Delhi unit president Mohammad Pervez Ahmed are trustees of the Empower India Foundation, its CEO Mohamed Shaffeeq N. says the think-tank is not connected to the organisation. "Some of our members may be PFI members, but that doesn't mean Empower India has any links to it," Shaffeeq told INDIA TODAY.

AN ISLAMIST OUTFIT?

The ban on PFI has not come out of the blue. It was already a banned outfit in Jharkhand for alleged "anti-national activities and links with terror outfits like ISIS". In 2017 itself, the NIA had submitted a report to the Union ministry of home affairs suggesting a ban on the PFI. States like Karnataka, Uttar Pradesh and Gujarat have also recommended the same.

The PFI, as it has done on multiple occasions before, has pleaded innocence, saying it has never been involved in any anti-national or violent activity. It termed the charges by NIA and ED "baseless sensationalism" and alleged that the raids were aimed at "creating an atmosphere of terror". However, the reaction of the PFI cadre to this pan-India crackdown—code-named Operation Octopus—did not reflect this commitment to non-violence. A flash hartal in Kerala, a PFI stronghold, saw violent incidents in many districts—attacks on buses, blocking of roads, and petrol bombs hurled at the homes of BJP-RSS leaders. PFI members also allegedly triggered violence in 17 districts in neighbouring Tamil Nadu.

The protests revealed the political muscle of the outfit in

A HISTORY OF VIOLENCE

Since 2010, the PFI has been accused of multiple incidents of murders, violence, terror and money laundering

2010

PFI men chop off a hand of **T.J. Joseph**, a Malayalam teacher at Newman College, Thodupuzha, Kerala, for an alleged insult to Prophet Mohammed in an internal question paper set by him; 12 PFI members convicted in 2015



2012

Kerala government tells the high court that PFI members were involved in 27 murders of CPI(M) and RSS cadres, 86 attempt to murder cases and over 125 cases of whipping up communal passions

2013

Police recover weapons, bombs and foreign cash from a PFI training camp in Kannur, Kerala. In 2016, a special NIA court convicts 21 PFI cadres arrested during the raid, though the high court later sets aside the convictions

2016

PFI cadres allegedly involved in the murder of RSS worker Rudresh (Karnataka). They were later accused of a spate of such killings—RSS workers Bibin (Kerala, 2017), Sharath Madivala (Karnataka, 2017), Sanjith and Nandu (Kerala, 2021), BJP leader Praveen Poojary (Karnataka, 2016), SFI leader Abhimanyu (Kerala, 2018), Hindu Munnani spokesperson C. Sasikumar (TN, 2016), PMK functionary V. Ramalingam (TN, 2019),

THE PFI FLASH HARTAL IN KERALA AFTER THE PAN-INDIA CRACKDOWN AND THE RESULTANT VIOLENCE SHOWED HOW BIG A BASE IT HAD IN THE STATE